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'A well-placed question, a thoughtful response to a failure, a welcoming of dissent, can change the game overnight'

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hen we were setting up this chat, you spoke of being a
'proud parent' of the concept of psychological safety, and
of seeing it 'come of age' out there in the world.

Yes. There's certainly been a growth in interest and awareness of the concept. It's way beyond me... I don't need to be, nor do I want to be, a kind of clearinghouse or bottleneck. The growth has been great to see, but that does bring with it many misconceptions. And for me, it's now time to stop just talking about psychological safety, and to start doing the things we need to create more candour.

I was talking with some people at a company the other day, and they said, 'Well, we know we first need to establish trust and psychological safety, and then we can engage in new behaviours. And that's going to take a long time.' I said, 'I think that's exactly wrong. I think it's about experimenting with engaging in new behaviours right away. And that's where the psychological safety will come from.'

But yes, the concept is certainly out there, affecting any number of work contexts where psychological safety matters, but it may matter or play out in different ways.

It's not a 'one-size-fits-all concept' then?

Well, it is, and it isn't! The 'one-size-fits-allness' of it is that we humans have a very strong predilection for holding back in the presence of hierarchy, and nearly every social situation is hierarchy in some form or another. It's the default mode, right? The default mode isn't to jump in and take interpersonal risks, for obvious reasons. In prehistoric times, that could get you killed.

And in modern times, we have this largely wrong-headed idea that people will think less of us if we disagree, for example. And sometimes they will, if they're not very thoughtful. So, feeling that it's risky to tell the truth, to share an idea, to ask for help, to admit a mistake, that's as old as the species. It's very consistent. But the implications of that vary across settings. For very routine work, it's less of a big deal because there are not as many degrees of freedom. For more creative or interdependent work, psychological safety matters.

How has your personal journey with psychological safety changed over the years?

As time has gone on, I've spent more of it in the field, not just as a researcher, but as a helper. The practical starts to matter more. So perhaps in the earlier days it was about prioritising solid evidence that this thing matters, that teams even within an organisation vary in psychological safety, that the learning they can do matters, supplemented by rich case studies to show the

at times catastrophic outcomes of low psychological safety and at times glorious outcomes of high psychological safety.

Then maybe just in the last decade, I've been far more attracted to the question of what we do to produce change, and how we do it. How do we change how well a group or organisation functions? Is it really doable? And not just with an abstract, 'you need to be more open' – but something more tangible. In rock climbing, you're always looking for a little piece of rock that's big enough to actually get a grip on... I think the handholds are what really interest me today. And, you know, one of the great things is there are a lot of people out there doing work to find these handholds.

You mention being more open... does that link to some of your work around authenticity?

Tomas Chamorro-Premuzic was the real driver on that work, and it reflects a book he wrote that I adore, *Don't Be Yourself: Why Authenticity is Overrated (and What to do Instead)*. I think there's a lot of confusion about authenticity. If you're a jerk and a bully, and you say 'well, this is just who I am'... that isn't actually helpful in any kind of work environment! A better bit of advice than 'bring your whole self' is 'bring your best self'.

That is consistent with my increasing emphasis on the skills of high-quality conversation. A lot of work requires people to talk to each other. High-quality conversation is what makes the difference in outcomes, and psychological safety enables that. People sharing their work-relevant thoughts and feelings, and listening intently when others are doing so. A healthy balance of advocacy and inquiry. Then we're getting somewhere, right? We're not going around in circles; we don't have the loudest voices dominating the conversation. And we all feel like we're learning something.

To do that well requires psychological safety, a sense of 'permission for candour', but it also requires some skill. Most of us don't have the skills we need for high-quality conversation. We end up asking closed or leading questions, for example, or we share our conclusions but not the reasoning that got us to them. As with authenticity, it starts with actively choosing learning over knowing. The authenticity that really matters is being open and honest about when you don't know something, and being appropriately vulnerable about the uncertainty that lies ahead.

Can you show us what that looks like in a conversation?

Well, say you're sitting there thinking, 'that guy's a total jerk. I can't believe he's saying that.' It could be seen as 'authenticity' to say that out loud. But that thought does not belong out loud. I could instead say, perhaps first to myself, 'Hold on here. I'm surprised he's saying that. I need to understand it better.' I don't want to be Pollyanna about it, but it's truly a skill to convert your surprise or disdain to actual curiosity. And there are very few times when that won't help you.

Hallmarks of a high-quality conversation

Attribute	Self-Assessment Questions
People either contributing or listening	• Is everyone engaged and sharing information and ideas candidly? • Or does it seem that people are holding back, reluctant to stand out or offend?
A mix of advocacy and inquiry	• What's the balance between advocacy (to explain and clarify) and inquiry (to understand someone else's thinking)? • Are people asking genuine questions to prompt candid responses?
A sense of mutual learning and progress	• Are people gaining a deeper understanding of the issue as the conversation goes on? (or defending their own perspectives more ardently?) • Are we getting closer to making a good decision? (Or, are we tiptoeing around issues, or going around in circles?)

So there are overlaps with active listening and assertive communication. Rather than psychological safety as a set of guidelines and reporting lines, there's actually no psychological safety without conversation.

I'd put it differently. Psychological safety describes the climate in which high-quality conversations can take root, but it also takes skills. We all know how to ask a question. But, if in the moment, we're thinking, 'I'm right. This other

person is wrong,' we won't ask a very good question. So we have to learn to catch ourselves – quickly challenge our automatic thinking and choose curiosity. If we can flip it – remind ourselves, 'it's genuinely in my self-interest to understand your thinking better' – we'll be fine. Sometimes, impression management needs to take a backseat, right? What's driving the car is our passion for learning, or for the project and who it serves.

What's Harvard like for that?

You know, like all organisations, it's variegated.

I can show you a department or research group that's really hierarchical and closed. And then I can show you another one that's unbelievably learning-oriented, supportive, and driven by curiosity – the things you'd want people at Harvard to be driven by. I happen to be in one of those groups, which is a great privilege.

That's similar to any organisation or industry... a multitude of different ways of interacting and engaging, depending on the culture or climate within those groups. So is it still possible to create a broader climate, when psychological safety can be so based on individual skills?

I think it is – through an ambitious effort to get everybody up to a level. The good news about variation is that it means some groups already have high psychological safety or an open, learning-oriented climate. You can shine a light on those people.

What this means is that a major lever is the skill and maturity of leaders in the middle – the team leaders, the branch bank managers, the restaurant managers in the fast food chain. They have an outsized influence. So, offering high-quality leadership and management training for anyone in a people management role is important.

I developed a case study on the Columbia Shuttle, the NASA tragedy in 2003. Sometimes, while teaching the case, I will ask people who they hold most responsible – the engineers who didn't speak up, the mission management leader who didn't create conditions conducive to speaking up, or the C-level executives who didn't emphasise the mission of discovery instead of production targets.

People raise their hands for each of the three options. And, they're right. Everyone is responsible. But if you wanted me to put my money somewhere, I'd put it with the mission management team leader. The leader in the middle –

leading the actual work of the mission. And this isn't a blame statement, it's a leverage statement. It's saying, 'Actually, you matter. You matter so much.' A well-placed question, a thoughtful response to a failure, a welcoming of dissent, can change the game.

So that middle layer has a responsibility to listen, to understand, to take that learning forward.

Exactly. And it's in their best interest, right? Nobody wants a failure to happen under their watch, whether that failure involves loss of life or the loss of a major account. Nobody likes telling the boss bad news.

That's the oldest finding in my field. But we can have one difficult moment – of speaking up – or we can have the tragic or undesired outcome down the road.

Agreed. Just going back to your personal story, and what you said about not acting as a gatekeeper for the idea. That's admirable... There are quite a few concepts in psychology where the originators have got quite 'proprietary' about them.

I didn't invent it, I discovered it. I just poked around. In hospitals, in a manufacturing company... and the poking around revealed very different norms and taken-for-granted assumptions around speaking up. I thought, 'that ought to matter in knowledge work'. And of course it does. I always felt like I've just pointed something out that's so darn obvious, I can't believe anyone even wants to read it. But I measured it, and in a robust, reliable way. It turns out to be a measure that's quite predictive – of all sorts of performance outcomes in all sorts of contexts. I just described a phenomenon that's there already, but it's not just 'the rainbow is blue', it's a phenomenon that we can do something about.

I'm just one person sitting in a university, though, right? I can't do much. But if other people are out there, experimenting and finding things that work, that's such a good thing.

And what has that changed for you? If you could go back in time, is there anything you would change in your focus?

I know a lot more now. I have a fuller understanding of the phenomenon because I've seen it in so many different places, unfolding in different ways. Would I change anything? All of the things I did got me to this place; they all played a role in some way. In two of my books, *Fearless Organization* and *Right Kind of Wrong*, I open with the psychological safety origin story.

It was only the fact that it's not easy to measure mistakes in the hospital space that led me to the unexpected discovery that high-performing teams are not error-free, but rather more willing and able to talk about error, which in turn helps them catch and correct errors before they cause harm. At the time, I was wildly disappointed that my results didn't work! But each of those stepping stones kept me moving forward.

Then, after a couple of studies, finding this pretty robust and predictive thing, I was done with it. I moved on to study other things. It wasn't until a little later that the world started getting interested. Charles Duhigg wrote this big [New York Times article](#) about Google's study of high-performing teams in 2016, and suddenly everybody wants to know more about psychological safety. That forced me to sit down and write *Fearless* because there was a need for more clarity.

Now that it's 'out there', do you worry about concept bleed? Do you see applications and contexts where you think 'that's not psychological safety'?

Oh yes, often! And that's why my former PhD student, Michaela Kerrissey, and I wrote *What People Get Wrong About Psychological Safety* in *Harvard Business Review*. If people are thinking psychological safety means 'I have to feel comfortable at all times', that's not only inaccurate, it's deeply unhelpful. No learning moment ever felt comfortable. You could say it's about feeling comfortable being uncomfortable. And, as Chris Argyris might put it, making that experience discussable.

Another one that worries me is 'I'm not the boss, so I can't do anything'. No, actually, whatever environment you're in, if you start asking more genuine questions, or calling more attention to uncertainty, or monitoring your own response to people disagreeing with you, and being more appreciative, you will make a difference. You will contribute to psychological safety in your team or work group. We can all make a little difference wherever we are. Collectively, that adds up.

Understood. I just had one final question... if we think about the current geopolitical landscape, do you feel it's more important than ever, from a professional and personal perspective, to understand the elements of psychological safety that will help us all?

I think the development of technology, and the political landscape, bring both uncertainty and fear. Now, the fear that we talk about and approach together

can be productive. When it's discussable, we can make progress in navigating the uncertainty together. But when fear is undiscussable, we become more isolated and more withdrawn; fear, in that case, is deeply unproductive.

Specifically across the political landscape, we have models of leadership that contradict most models that come from research that we've been teaching for a long time. Leadership is about harnessing others' efforts to produce something no one could do alone that makes the world better. It's generous, curious, appreciative of others' efforts and ideas, open to being wrong, and ultimately about serving, not benefiting self or showing off.

We've known for 40, 50 years what good leadership looks like and what it can accomplish. It takes honesty, humility, engagement, drive, passion and a commitment to the future. When these attributes are not only absent, but their opposites are present... It's cognitively confusing. What does that mean for the value of research and of ideas? What does that mean for the world? Something's off.

Are enough of us humans capable of recognising the real thing? If you take as a given, which I do, that we need to be building learning organisations on a learning planet... then there is work to be done to ensure a thriving future. But if enough of us are aware of the difference and are drawn toward the kinds of leaders that can help and serve, then there's hope. We've seen too many times throughout history that it doesn't end well when people fall prey to scapegoating and easy promises. But we cannot attribute full causality to leaders. We also need to look at what we are doing, individually and collectively, that allows so many people to choose easy answers over hard work, soul-searching, and learning.

Psychological safety merely describes an environment where we can do the hard work, soul-searching, and learning together. Leadership that helps create that environment is vital.

- This interview is part of a [psychological safety special](#).

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